

SmartCare Multispeciality Hospital — Laboratory Test Preparation & Sample Collection Guide

Document ID: SC-DOC-006
Document Name: SmartCare Hospital Laboratory Test Preparation & Sample Collection Guide
Version: 1.0
Status: Active
Owner: Department of Pathology, Biochemistry & Laboratory Medicine
Effective Date: 01 September 2026
Last Updated: 01 September 2026
Review Frequency: Every 6 months
Target Audience: Outpatients, Inpatients, Phlebotomists, Nursing Staff, Laboratory Technicians, and AI Assistant

1. Purpose & Scope

1.1 Purpose

Diagnostic laboratory test accuracy depends heavily on rigorous pre-analytical patient preparation and precise sample collection techniques. This guide outlines standard patient preparation instructions, fasting protocols, specimen collection methods, criteria for specimen rejection, turnaround times, and report delivery mechanisms at SmartCare Multispeciality Hospital.

1.2 Scope

This guide governs all clinical diagnostic testing performed by the NABL-accredited SmartCare Central Diagnostic Laboratories, including Clinical Biochemistry, Hematology, Clinical Pathology, Microbiology, Serology, Molecular Diagnostics, and Histopathology.

2. Laboratory Operating Hours & Location

- **Outpatient Sample Collection Phlebotomy Center:**
 - Location: Ground Floor, Laboratory Services Wing (adjacent to Central Atrium).
 - Operating Hours: Monday through Saturday, **6:00 AM to 8:00 PM**.
 - Fasting Blood Sugar Collections: Commences daily at **6:00 AM**.
- **Inpatient & Emergency STAT Laboratory:**
 - Location: Level 1, Core Diagnostic Facility.
 - Operating Hours: **24 Hours a Day, 365 Days a Year**.
 - Dedicated rapid-turnaround testing for emergency resuscitation, ICUs, and operating theaters.

3. General Pre-Analytical Preparation Principles

CRITICAL CLINICAL DIRECTIVE:

Not all laboratory tests require fasting. Preparation requirements depend strictly upon the specific analyte being evaluated. Patients should always follow the explicit instructions printed on their laboratory requisition slip or provided by their treating physician.

3.1 Fasting Requirements Matrix

- **Strict 10 to 12 Hour Fasting Required:**

- Fasting Blood Sugar (FBS)
- Complete Lipid Profile (Total Cholesterol, Triglycerides, HDL, LDL, VLDL)
- Fasting Serum Insulin
- Serum Gastrin
- *Instruction:* Consume dinner by 8:00 PM the night prior. Do not eat any solid food, milk, tea, coffee, juice, or chew gum. Drink plain water to stay normally hydrated.
- **8 Hour Fasting Required:**
- Comprehensive Metabolic Panel (CMP)
- Liver Function Tests (LFT) (preferred for accurate bilirubin baseline)
- Serum Iron and Total Iron Binding Capacity (TIBC)
- **Non-Fasting (Random) Tests — No Fasting Required:**
- Complete Blood Count (CBC) / Hemogram
- Glycated Hemoglobin (HbA1c)
- Kidney Function Test (Creatinine, Urea, Electrolytes)
- Thyroid Function Tests (TSH, Free T3, Free T4)
- Infectious disease serology (Dengue, Malaria, Typhoid, HIV, Hepatitis B/C)
- Urine Routine & Microscopy
- Cardiac Troponin-I, D-Dimer, Prothrombin Time / INR

3.2 Hydration Guidelines

Unless undergoing a specific fluid restriction protocol prescribed by a nephrologist or cardiologist, patients are strongly encouraged to **drink plain water** before blood and urine collection. Adequate hydration facilitates smooth vein access, prevents vasovagal fainting, and ensures adequate urine volume.

3.3 Medication Disclosures & Timing

- **Thyroid Medications:** For TSH testing, patients should generally take their morning thyroid medication (e.g., levothyroxine) *after* the blood sample has been drawn, unless instructed otherwise by their endocrinologist.
- **Diabetes Medications / Insulin:** Do **not** take morning diabetes tablets or morning insulin injections while fasting, as this can trigger severe life-threatening hypoglycemia. Administer morning diabetes medication only when consuming breakfast after the fasting sample has been drawn.
- **Blood Thinners (Anticoagulants):** Inform the phlebotomist if you take aspirin, clopidogrel, warfarin, or apixaban, so that prolonged pressure is applied to the puncture site to avoid hematoma formation.

4. Step-by-Step Sample Collection Protocols

4.1 Venous Blood Sample Collection

1. **Patient Verification:** The phlebotomist verifies patient identity using two unique identifiers: Full Name and SmartCare UHID barcode.
2. **Site Selection:** Patient is seated comfortably. An arm vein (median cubital or cephalic) is palpated. A sterile latex-free tourniquet is applied for less than 60 seconds.
3. **Aseptic Cleansing:** The skin is disinfected with a 70% isopropyl alcohol swab in concentric circles and allowed to air dry completely for 30 seconds.
4. **Blood Draw:** A sterile, single-use vacuum collection needle is used to draw blood directly into designated color-coded Vacutainer tubes (e.g., Purple EDTA for CBC, Grey for glucose, Gold/Yellow Gel for biochemistry).
5. **Post-Draw Care:** Needle is withdrawn and discarded in a sharps bin. Firm pressure is applied with sterile cotton gauze for 3 to 5 minutes. An adhesive bandage is applied.

4.2 Clean-Catch Midstream Urine Collection

For accurate urine routine, microscopy, and culture testing without bacterial contamination:

1. Obtain a sterile, pre-labeled plastic container from the lab counter. Do not touch the inside of the cup or lid.
2. Wash hands thoroughly with soap and water.
3. Cleanse the genital area with clean water:

- **Females:** Cleanse the labial area from front to back.
 - **Males:** Retract foreskin if uncircumcised and cleanse the urethral opening.
4. Begin urinating into the toilet bowl for the first 1 to 2 seconds.
 5. Without stopping the stream, pass the collection container into the urine stream and collect approximately **30 to 50 mL** of midstream urine.
 6. Void the remaining urine into the toilet.
 7. Securely screw the cap onto the cup. Submit the sample to the laboratory counter within **15 minutes** of collection.

4.3 Stool Sample Collection

- Collect stool in the provided sterile wide-mouth container with a built-in collection spatula.
- Avoid contamination with toilet bowl water, urine, or toilet paper.
- Collect 5 to 10 grams of stool (approximately walnut-sized) from areas showing mucus or blood if present. Submit within 1 hour.

5. Sample Rejection Criteria

To protect patient safety and diagnostic reliability, the laboratory will reject specimens under the following conditions and request a recollection:

- **Mislabeled / Unlabeled Containers:** Specimen tube lacks patient name, UHID, or date.
- **Hemolyzed Blood Sample:** Ruptured red blood cells invalidating potassium, enzyme, and cardiac tests.
- **Clotted Anticoagulant Tube:** Clots detected in EDTA or Citrate hematology tubes.
- **Insufficient Sample Volume (QNS):** Insufficient blood or urine quantity to perform the requested analyzer panels.
- **Wrong Tube Type:** Sample drawn in an incorrect Vacutainer (e.g., glucose drawn in heparin).
- **Delayed Submission:** Urine or stool sample held at room temperature exceeding 2 hours.

6. Report Turnaround Times (TAT) & Access

Test Category	Typical Processing Time	Delivery Channels
Emergency STAT Tests (Troponin, ABG, CBC)	30 to 60 Minutes	Immediate clinical push to ER / ICU monitors.
Routine Blood / Urine (CBC, LFT, KFT, Lipid)	2 to 4 Hours	Patient Portal, WhatsApp PDF link, Stamped Print.
Specialized Hormones & Vitamins (Thyroid, Vit D, B12)	6 to 8 Hours	Patient Portal, WhatsApp PDF link, Stamped Print.
Microbiology Urine / Blood Culture	48 to 72 Hours	Preliminary at 24 hrs; Final sensitivity at 48–72 hrs.
Histopathology / Biopsy Examination	4 to 7 Business Days	Pathologist reviewed; Stamped report at MRD.

7. RAG Knowledge Search & Question Triggers

- **Trigger Queries:** "Do I need to fast for my blood test?", "Can I drink water before a fasting blood test?", "What time does the lab open?", "Can I take my thyroid medicine before the test?", "How do I collect a clean-catch urine sample?", "How long does a blood test report take?", "Can I get my lab reports on WhatsApp?", "Why was my blood sample rejected?"
- **Standardized Fact Base:** Main lab opens at 6:00 AM Mon–Sat. Fasting blood sugar and lipid profile require 10–12 hours fasting. Plain water is permitted. Emergency lab operates 24/7. Routine reports are available in 2–4 hours via web portal, app, and WhatsApp.

8. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1: What are the operating hours of the outpatient laboratory?

A: The main outpatient laboratory collection center is open Monday through Saturday from 6:00 AM to 8:00 PM. Emergency and inpatient lab testing runs 24/7.

Q2: Can I drink water before a fasting blood test?

A: Yes. You can and should drink plain water while fasting. Water does not affect blood sugar or cholesterol levels and helps ensure smooth vein access. Do not drink tea, coffee, milk, or juice.

Q3: How many hours should I fast for a lipid profile (cholesterol) test?

A: A complete lipid profile requires strict fasting for **10 to 12 hours**. Do not fast for more than 14 hours, as prolonged starvation can artificially skew lipid measurements.

Q4: Does a Complete Blood Count (CBC) test require fasting?

A: No. A Complete Blood Count (CBC) or hemogram can be drawn at any time of day regardless of food intake.

Q5: Should I take my morning blood pressure medication before my blood test?

A: Yes. Blood pressure medications should be taken at their regular scheduled time with a few sips of plain water, unless your treating doctor has specifically advised otherwise.

Q6: Should I take my diabetes medicine before a fasting blood sugar test?

A: No. Never take morning diabetes tablets or morning insulin while fasting. Bring your medications with you to the hospital and take them with breakfast immediately after your blood sample has been drawn.

Q7: Can I take my thyroid medication before my thyroid test?

A: For routine TSH, Free T3, and Free T4 monitoring, it is generally recommended to draw the blood sample in the morning *before* taking your daily levothyroxine tablet. Take the tablet immediately after the draw.

Q8: What is a Post-Prandial Blood Sugar (PPBS) test?

A: PPBS measures your blood glucose exactly **2 hours after the start of a meal**. If you begin eating breakfast at 8:00 AM, your blood sample must be drawn at 10:00 AM sharp.

Q9: Does an HbA1c test require fasting?

A: No. The HbA1c test reflects your average blood sugar levels over the past 3 months and is completely unaffected by recent meals. It can be taken at any time.

Q10: What is a "clean-catch midstream" urine sample?

A: It is a sample where you void the first few drops of urine into the toilet, collect the middle portion in the sterile cup, and discard the last portion. This washes away normal skin bacteria and ensures accurate results.

Q11: Can a urine sample be collected during a menstrual period?

A: If possible, avoid routine urine testing during menstruation to prevent red blood cells from contaminating the sample. If medically urgent, notify the laboratory staff so it can be annotated on the requisition.

Q12: How long does it take to get routine blood test results?

A: Routine blood tests such as CBC, Liver Function (LFT), Kidney Function (KFT), and blood sugar are typically ready within **2 to 4 hours**.

Q13: How will I receive my laboratory test reports?

A: Reports are automatically uploaded to the SmartCare Patient Portal, sent as a secure PDF link via WhatsApp/SMS, and available as printed stamped copies at the Ground Floor Lab Report Counter.

Q14: Why is it necessary to hold pressure on the puncture site after blood collection?

A: Holding firm, direct pressure for 3 to 5 minutes allows a natural platelet plug to seal the punctured vein, preventing bruising (hematoma) and subcutaneous bleeding.

Q15: What should I do if I feel dizzy or faint during blood collection?

A: Inform the phlebotomist immediately. They will recline your phlebotomy chair, elevate your legs, and allow you to rest until you feel completely stable. You can also request to have your blood drawn while lying down.

Q16: Why was my blood sample rejected due to "hemolysis"?

A: Hemolysis occurs when red blood cells rupture, releasing intracellular potassium and enzymes into the serum. This makes accurate measurement impossible and requires a fresh, gentle recollection to ensure patient safety.

Q17: Does Vitamin D or Vitamin B12 testing require fasting?

A: Fasting is not strictly required for Vitamin D or B12, but an overnight fast of 6 to 8 hours is preferred to avoid serum turbidity from dietary fats.

Q18: How long does a urine culture report take?

A: Preliminary culture findings are noted at 24 hours, but final organism identification and antibiotic susceptibility results take **48 to 72 hours** to allow bacterial colonies to grow.

Q19: Can I collect a stool sample at home and bring it to the hospital?

A: Yes, provided you collect it in an approved sterile container provided by the SmartCare laboratory and deliver it to the lab counter within **1 to 2 hours** of collection.

Q20: Can I get my blood sample collected at home?

A: Yes. SmartCare provides a certified home phlebotomy sample collection service across Hyderabad. Call +91-40-6999-4455 to schedule a home collection.

Q21: Are laboratory reference ranges the same for men, women, and children?

A: No. Normal biological reference ranges vary based on age, gender, and pregnancy status. Your report displays specific reference intervals matched to your profile.

Q22: Do I need a doctor's prescription to get routine blood tests done?

A: While a doctor's prescription is recommended, SmartCare permits self-requested preventive health checkup packages and screening panels (e.g., Master Health Checkup, Executive Cardiac Profile).

Q23: What should I do if my test result is highlighted in bold or flagged as "Abnormal"?

A: Flagged values indicate results outside standard statistical population averages. You should review the findings with your treating doctor, who will evaluate the numbers in the context of your overall clinical symptoms.

Q24: Does the laboratory operate on Sundays?

A: The main outpatient collection desk is closed on Sundays, but emergency STAT diagnostic testing for hospital inpatients and trauma arrivals operates continuously 24 hours a day.

Q25: Can someone else collect my printed lab reports on my behalf?

A: Yes. An authorized representative may collect printed reports by presenting the original sample collection receipt slip or an authorization letter along with the patient's UHID.

9. Official Contact Directory

- **Diagnostic Laboratory Main Reception:** Ground Floor, Lab Services Wing
- **Direct Telephone:** +91-40-6999-4455 / +91-40-6999-4456
- **Emergency STAT Laboratory (24/7):** Level 1 Diagnostic Wing, Ext. 1022
- **Home Sample Collection Helpline:** +91-40-6999-4400
- **Email:** labreports@smartcarehospital-demo.org / pathology@smartcarehospital-demo.org